

They were very rudimentary.

It was difficult even to communicate with my family when I was away for a competition. I had to look for a telephone, and I could not even use the ones in the hotel because the charges were too expensive!

What do you think you might have achieved if you were competing today with all the available technology, specialised support, and modern equipment?

This is a hypothetical question. It is true that technology has advanced a lot now. The weight of just one of the shoes I jumped in would probably be more than that of a pair of jumping shoes that athletes use these days. There is also far more technical knowledge now in terms of medical support and muscle training. We had injuries that put us out for six months. These days, you can recover from those in maybe one month.

Back then, it wasn't easy to get knowledge. Today, you can just put somebody's name on *YouTube*, and the whole analysis of your competitors will come up. I remember that in the 1990s, I had to hand-crank a film player just to watch one minute of video footage. There was no slo-mo, no special cameras like today.

Today, my son is training in Spain, and I can help him from Cuba. I can look at his video and tell him where he has to do better.

But at the same time, I don't think you can compare the two eras.

If I had all those facilities, then maybe I wouldn't have been as mentally prepared, keyed in, and focused as I was back in the day. Additionally, I think what helped me was the kind of competition I had. It wasn't just the jumpers I was competing with, but also my teammates who were training with me in Cuba. They were very serious athletes, and we trained really hard with each other.

What, according to you, is a perfect jump?

It starts when I concentrate well. I start running at a good speed and,

more importantly, develop a good rhythm. After that comes a powerful take-off and then the jump itself. Each position should come at the right moment. And finally, you need to enjoy your jump. When all of this comes together, you really get joy out of it. You feel as if you are flying!

Did you ever make a perfect jump?

I don't think I ever did a perfect jump, although I always dreamed about it. I was always chasing that jump. I think there were jumps where I did not clear 2.45m, but those were executed almost perfectly, according to what I was visualising.

That is why I think that, mentally, the high jump is the most difficult discipline. Your best effort might not be what you are truly capable of. For example, if you execute your most technically perfect jump but the bar is set at 2.30m, then only 2.30m will be recorded against your name, even if you feel you jumped well beyond that. And then, when you have to attempt 2.37m, you might not produce your best jump. Sometimes your medal-winning jump might not even be your best jump. That is very different from something like the javelin, where your technically best throw is usually also your longest.



National icon: Cuban President Fidel Castro honours Javier Sotomayor, the nation's most soaring symbol of excellence, whose world record of 2.45m was forged in an era when Cuban athletes were expected not just to medal, but to win.

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Do you think you achieved what you wanted to?

Since I was 15, my goal has been to be the best in the world. At that age, my immediate target was to be the best in the youth category.

Once I achieved that, I thought, "Now I want to be the best in the world."

By then, someone had already jumped 2.42m, so I knew I had to do better than that.

But even after I became the best in the world, I always wanted to do better than myself. I kept setting the bar higher.

Even though I was never able to go beyond 2.45m, in my mind, that was always possible; that was always the target. I wanted to reach 2.46 or 2.47m. So by my own assessment, I fell short a little bit.

That is why I repeat that the most important thing is what is in the mind of the athlete, the desire to be better than yourself every single day.